

Appendix 4: Supplementary Information on the Sustainable Development Timeline

UN Conference on Human Development

What: UN Conference on Human Development

Where: Stockholm

When: 1972

Detail:

- This was the first time the international community met to consider the global environment and development needs.
- The conference's original purpose was to look at large-scale industrial pollution, but it ended up also addressing concerns about accelerated population growth and the depletion and destruction of the environment.

Result(s):

- The Stockholm Declaration and Action Plan was developed, which defined the principles for the preservation and enhancement of the natural environment and highlighted the need to support people in this process.
- The creation of UNEP, the United Nations Environment Programme, which collects, processes and distributes information on the environment. Located in Nairobi, it was the first UN agency to be based away from UN headquarters in New York.
- An international focus on environmental issues developed and leading non-governmental organisations were increasingly able to make their voices heard. UNEP joined forces with the International Union for the Conservation of Nature (IUCN) and WWF (formed in 1961) to voice their own concerns regarding depleting natural resources.
- This led to the production of a World Conservation Strategy in 1980.

Reference(s): <http://www.wwf.org.uk/wssd/background.asp>

The Brundtland Commission

What: In 1983 the World Commission on Environment and Development (WCED) - also known as the Brundtland Commission after its Norwegian chairperson, Gro Harland Brundtland - was formed. The Brundtland Commission was comprised of 23 commissioners from 22 countries representing developed and developing countries and the communist block.

When: 1983

Detail:

- The Commission was set up to focus on the *causes* of environmental problems rather than the *effects* of environmental degradation
- The task of the Commission was to formulate a world programme for change.
- The Brundtland Commission was to re-examine the serious environmental and developmental problems on the earth, formulate realistic recommendations as to their solutions as well as see to it that our progress is achieved through a development which does not harm the resources of future generations.
- It drew attention to the fact that economic development often leads to deterioration, not an improvement, in the quality of people's lives. Just because it is new does not mean that it is better - or at least not for everybody!
- The Commission therefore called for a form of sustainable development that meets the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.
- Its brief was to investigate links between the issues of environment and development that were at the time uncertain but strongly suspected.
- It held meetings on every continent with people from all walks of life

Result(s):

The commission presented its final report, *Our Common Future*, to the UN General Assembly in 1987.

Reference(s): http://www.ekotopia.nu/utveckling/utveckling_eng.htm
[http://www.srds.ndirect.co.uk/sustaina.htm#The%20Bruntland%20Report%20\(1987\)](http://www.srds.ndirect.co.uk/sustaina.htm#The%20Bruntland%20Report%20(1987))

Interesting Fact(s): The name Brundtland Commission comes from its chairwoman, the Norwegian Prime Minister Gro Harlem Brundtland.

Our Common Future

What: The final report of the Brundtland Commission

When: 1987

Detail: The report illustrated the widespread human concern for the state of the environment.

Result(s):

- It popularised the phrase 'sustainable development' (defined as a way to meet 'the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs').
- Framed much of what would become the 40 chapters of *Agenda 21* and the 27 principles of the *Rio Declaration* on Environment and Development.

Reference(s): <http://www.wwf.org.uk/wssd/background.asp>

The Earth Summit

What: The UN Conference on Environment and Development or the Earth Summit

Where: Rio de Janeiro, Brazil

When: 1992

Detail:

- The Earth Summit was attended by political leaders from 178 countries and by major environmental organisations with a total of 30,000 participants.
- The Summit accepted *Agenda 21* and the *Rio Declaration*, which outlined key policies for achieving sustainable development that meets the needs of the poor and recognizes the limits of development to meet global needs.

Result(s):

- Developed a global acceptance to the principle of sustainable development
- Brought the environment and development into the public arena again.
- Developed the *Rio Declaration*.
- Led to the development of two legally binding documents; a) Biological diversity and b) The Framework Convention on Sustainable Development.
- Developed a Framework Convention on Climate Change
- Developed a Statement of Forest Principles - a set of principles to underlie the sustainable management of forests worldwide.
- Led to the creation of formal sustainable development councils and committees in as many as 150 nations around the world.
- 1/3 of African countries have introduced new environmental impact assessment policies, laws and procedures
- Led to the formation of the Commission for Sustainable Development (CSD).
- Led to the establishment of the permanent Global Environmental Facility that has supported some \$6 billion worth of projects to assist developing countries to protect climate, biodiversity, and international waters.
- In response to the summit the British government announced the creation of the UK Darwin Initiative for the Survival of Species.

Reference(s): <http://www.un.org/geninfo/bp/enviro.html>

Agenda 21

What: A comprehensive programme of action for global action in all areas of sustainable development that includes the United Nations, Governments, and other groups.

When: 1992, developed from the *Earth Summit*.

Detail:

- Agenda 21 addresses today's pressing problems and aims to prepare the world for the challenges of the next century.
- It contains detailed proposals for action in social and economic areas (such as combating poverty, changing patterns of production and consumption and addressing demographic dynamics), and for conserving and managing the natural resources that are the basis for life — protecting the atmosphere, oceans and biodiversity; preventing deforestation; and promoting sustainable agriculture.
- It was adopted by more than 178 governments at *the Earth Summit*.
- AGENDA 21 recognises that:
 - humans depend on the Earth to sustain life
 - there are linkages between human activity and environmental issues
 - global concerns require local actions
 - people have to be involved in planning developments for their own communities if such developments are to be sustainable
- The success of Agenda 21 is first and foremost the responsibility of individual governments.
- The success of Agenda 21 also requires increased financial aid to developing countries.

Result(s):

About 85 countries have produced national Agenda 21 which is based on Agenda 21, but instead of global are national sustainable development strategies or environmental action plans.

Website: <http://www.un.org/esa/sustdev/agenda21.htm>
[http://www.srds.ndirect.co.uk/sustaina.htm#The%20Bruntland%20Report%20\(1987\)](http://www.srds.ndirect.co.uk/sustaina.htm#The%20Bruntland%20Report%20(1987))
<http://www.un.org/esa/sustdev/agenda21chapter1.htm>
<http://www.un.org/geninfo/bp/envirp2.html>

Agenda 2000

What: The Federal government's Department of Foreign Affairs and International Trade (DFAIT) Agenda 2000 Sustainable Development Strategy. *Agenda 2000* is the first sustainable development strategy of the Department of DFAIT and sets out the Department's action plan to achieve its sustainable development objectives through to the year 2000.

Where: Ottawa, Canada

When: 1997

Detail:

- The goal of Agenda 2000 is to integrate sustainable development principles into other federal departmental operations ranging from forests to trade.
- The rationale behind the agenda is based on an understanding that economic growth and development issues are often complicated by the effects of trade barriers and international indebtedness, and by social development concerns for humanitarian issues such as the use of child labour, the inability to meet basic human needs globally, and the protection of human rights.
- The agenda was developed when all departments in parliament were instructed to develop sustainable development strategies in 1995 by a federal law (amendments to the Auditor General Act 1995).

Result(s):

- Awareness of the significance of sustainable development has increased both inside and outside the Department.
- Change has been slow, but DFAIT is committed to slow and steady gains.
- The implementation of *Agenda 2000* demonstrated how ambitious, wide-ranging, and in some instances, unrealistic some of its objectives were.
- A consultative process with interested parties outside DFAIT that included representatives from other federal departments and agencies, provincial, territorial and municipal levels of government, industry, non-governmental organizations, academia, Aboriginal groups, and individual Canadians.
- An Agenda 2000 Progress Report
- An Agenda 2003

Website(s) http://greenware.ca/corporate/can_fed.html
<http://www.dfait-maeci.gc.ca/sustain/SustainDev/agenda2k/01-en.asp>
<http://www.dfait-maeci.gc.ca/sustain/agenda2003/intro-en.asp>

Rio + 5

What: The Earth Summit Review

Where: New York

When: 1997

Detail:

- The goal of Rio + 5 was to assess the progress made since the 1992 Earth Summit.
- Identified several gaps with regard to social equity and poverty due to falling official development assistance to poor countries and growing international debt.
- In short, the Assembly concluded that the quality of the environment had continued to deteriorate despite the agreements secured at Rio.

Result:

- Called for stronger implementation of the growing number of international agreements and conventions which pertain to the environment and development.
- Concern regarding this apparent apathy was further reinforced with the failure to strengthen the Convention on Climate Change at the 1997 international meeting in Kyoto.

Website: http://www.un.org/esa/sustdev/CSD_5th.htm
<http://www.wwf.org.uk/wssd/background.asp>

Commission for Sustainable Development (CSD)

- The Commission for Sustainable Development (CSD) was set up to ensure the effective implementation and follow-up of the decisions and pledges made at Rio.
- Increasingly, it has been dedicated to monitoring the lack of progress since Rio.
- Ironically, the CSD has faced widespread criticism for being just as ineffective and under-resourced as many of the grand ideas agreed on at Rio. The struggle over Kyoto, for example, has illustrated that there is a long way to go before nation states deliver on the pledges made in 1992.
- Established as a functional commission of the Economic and Social Council
- The Commission is composed of 53 members elected for terms of office of three years, meets annually for a period of two to three weeks and receives substantive and technical services from the Department of Economic and Social Affairs/Division for Sustainable Development.
- The Commission reports to the Economic and Social Council and, through it, to the Second Committee of the General Assembly.
- Thirteen members are elected from Africa; eleven from Asia; ten from Latin America and the Caribbean; six from Eastern Europe; and thirteen from Western Europe and other.
- The present Chairman of the CSD is Professor Bedrich Moldan, Czech Republic.

- In very broad terms, the role of the Commission is threefold:
 - to review progress at the international, regional and national levels in the implementation of recommendations and commitments contained in the final documents of the United Nations Conference on Environment and Development (UNCED), namely: Agenda 21; the Rio Declaration on Environment and Development; and the Non-legally Binding Authoritative Statement of Principles for a Global Consensus on the Management, Conservation and Sustainable Development of All Types of Forests (also known as the Forest Principles)
 - to elaborate policy guidance and options for future activities to follow up UNCED and achieve sustainable development
 - to promote dialogue and build partnerships for sustainable development with governments, the international community and the major groups identified in Agenda 21 as key actors outside the central government who have a major role to play in the transition towards sustainable development including women, youth, indigenous peoples, non-governmental organizations, local authorities, workers and trade unions, business and industry, the scientific community, and farmers

Website: <http://www.un.org/esa/sustdev/csdback.htm>

Canada's Response to Our Common Future

What: The creation of the National Round Table on the Environment and the Economy

Where: Canada

When: 1989

Detail:

- Comprised of representatives from government, industry, science, education, NGOs and native peoples to advise the Prime Minister of Canada on policies for Sustainable Development and to develop strategies for action.

Result(s):

- Learning for a Sustainable Future, a sustainable development education program is a spin off of the round table.

Resource(s): <http://www.schoolnet.ca/learning/>

The International Institute for Sustainable Development

What: IISD is an organization that promotes the transition toward a sustainable future. It seeks to demonstrate how human ingenuity can be applied to improve the well-being of the environment, economy and society.

When: 1988

Where: Winnipeg, Manitoba

Detail:

- In 1988, Prime Minister Brian Mulroney announced, to the General Assembly of the United Nations the creation of the International Institute for Sustainable Development in Winnipeg.
- IISD officially opened in March 1990.

Website: www.iisd.org